

Out of the Komtur's sight, his grid of colours and signs folded away in your bag, his order in your hand. Back into the carnival — and all the way across the masked, roaring city the same talk keeps catching at you, none of it kind to the master you now serve. That the Komtur himself wanted to come to terms with the townsmen, and Marienburg forbade it — that even he thinks the cause half-lost. That the Grand Master has sat silent in his castle for weeks and answered no letter, as if he had washed his hands of this place. That even the bishops are turning — the Pomesanian one sheltered the rebels' own Union under his roof, once. You push it all down. Somewhere across this din there is a cook's kitchen that is not a kitchen at all, and a part for you to play in it.

INFILTRATE PICCOLO

You would serve the Order? Here is how you earn the right.

There is a cook in this town. JORDAN. He keeps a place they call PICCOLO — and it is no kitchen. It is the traitors' own nest, where their Secret Council is fed and sheltered and lays its plans.

Tonight you walk in as one of *them*. The Council's couriers come and go from that kitchen all night, and the carnival lends you a face for free — PASS YOURSELF AS THE COUNCIL'S OWN, AND THE COOK WILL TAKE YOU FOR FRIENDS. He feeds his people without a second thought. Let him feed you.

YOUR TASK IS TO KNOW THE MAN. Not his words — his *person*. Sit at his board, take what he puts in your hand, and while you eat at his hearth, watch him close. Mark what no friend would trouble to mark: THE COLOUR HE WEARS, AND THE ONE THING NEVER OUT OF HIS HAND. Fix them in your memory and carry them back to me — by such marks the Order knows its enemy, and will know him again, wherever he runs. Bring me the man, drawn in those two strokes.

And let the meal be no waste. The castle bars its gates against the siege to come, and the Order's men must be fed; what fills traitors' bellies may as well fill ours. TAKE THE TOKEN HE HANDS YOU AND SPEND IT TO THE LAST — every bowl you empty at their hearth is one the Council will not. Let the traitors feed the Order's own, and never know whom they fed.

Eat, take his measure, and slip back into the dark. Do not be a face he remembers.

— A.

One of the Council's people, then — for an hour, over a borrowed supper, with a careful eye on the man with the ladle. Eat their bread, learn his face, and be gone before anyone wonders whose side you came in on.

↪ GAME MASTER — Bring the cook back to the Game Master — he keeps to the Rynek Staromiejski (the Old Town market square) — in two strokes — THE COLOUR HE WEARS AND THE THING HE CARRIES. With those — and the cook's own meal-token spent at his board — you have done what was asked; what comes next is waiting there.